

ODI World Cup

1983

Indian cricket had arrived in 1971, beating England in England for the first time, then crafting an away win against the Windies. Sunil Gavaskar's blend of class and appetite for runs invited comparisons with the legendary Bradman. It was as if we were bodily lifted from the mofussil and granted the highest nobility. Then another supernova burst on the horizon—at Pavilion End, rather. Kapil Dev was the sinew India had lacked. The past seemed like a chronicle of wimpishness as his bombastic bat and seaming red ball electrified the cricket-crazy masses. Even so, no punter would've put a penny on his boys at the ODI World Cup in England. Kapil's Devils reaching the finals at Lord's, then beating the mighty Windies, was nothing short of a natal moment for new India.



T20 World Cup

2007

India, now seen as the home of the IPL, was originally a laggard in the shortest format of the game, being totally addicted to an ODI diet for a quarter century. The T20 World Cup 2007 in South Africa changed everything—even if India was a reluctant participant. M.S. Dhoni's youthful team, bristling with energy and resembling the gleaming machines of the new health industry they were groomed amidst, proved equal to the task of producing the always-on turbo power and superquick reflexes T20 demanded. The unlikely victory against Pakistan in the final changed India all over again; within a year, it had launched the cash-rich Indian Premier League that was to transform the face of world cricket forever.

Sushil Kumar's Bronze and Silver

Beijing, London Olympics: 2008-12

Tradition gives wrestling a special place in India's sporting imagination. Unsurprisingly, our first individual Olympic medallist was a wrestler, K.D. Jadhav. But it took 56 years for a second. Tradition itself was an albatross: generations struggled to adjust to the speed of modern wrestling. And they gave Greco-Roman—which disallows below-the-waist holds—a total miss, focusing on freestyle, akin to the old Indian style. Enter Sushil Kumar... and Yogeshwar Dutt (London), Sakshi Malik (Rio 2016), Ravi Dahiya and Bajrang Punia (Tokyo 2020) were soon strutting over those foam mats.



P.V. Sindhu's Silver and Bronze

Rio, Tokyo Olympics: 2016-20

Prakash Padukone, All England champion and World No. 1 in 1980. Pullela Gopichand, All England 2001.... India's badminton superstars seemed to come like a very occasional smash at the net before Saina Nehwal announced her arrival with a bronze at the 2012 London Olympics. That event spoke of how Gopichand's coaching was revolutionising Indian badminton. The tall and lithe P.V. Sindhu seemed to embody a whole new generation that played on the world stage as if to the manner born. Her two Olympics feats and India's 2022 Thomas Cup for men now frame a present where we now have a complete game.

